

cover story TERROR

hubs, its cyber cities, its holiest shrines, its trains and buses, its busy markets and as the most recent serial blasts in Jaipur show, even the biggest tourist spot. No place seems safe anymore. Union Home Secretary Madhukar Gupta told INDIA TODAY, "The obvious intent is to create trouble at different places in the hinterland and foment a communal divide."

Terrorists are picking the most innocuous everyday objects for delivering mayhem, making the task of detection difficult. In Jaipur, bicycles fitted with timer devices were used as bomb carriers. The modus operandi employed was a near-repeat of the six serial blasts that rocked the courts of Lucknow, Varanasi and Faizabad within a span of 25 minutes in November last year. Earlier, in the 2006 Mumbai train blasts, terrorists used pressure cookers as improvised bombs.

So how can we stop these attacks?

BETTER INTELLIGENCE QUOTIENT

Soon after the Jaipur blasts, there was the all-too-familiar passing-the-buck between the Centre and the state over the apparent intelligence lapse. As after every terror attack, the Intelligence Bureau (IB) claims it did warn the state of an impending strike. While saying that the IB hadn't specified Jaipur as the target, Sriprakash Jaiswal, Union minister of state for home affairs, also points out that under the Constitution, law and order is a state subject and the state police, too, should have stepped up surveillance, especially since a bomb exploded in the Ajmer Sharif dargah in October last year. Police officials, though, compare IB warnings to routine weather forecasts lacking in clarity. "If we are told there is going to be a blast in the city and nothing else, how are we to proceed?" asks a senior Mumbai police official.

Intelligence wings are often seen as dumping grounds for police officials or as tools for gathering political intelligence. Most states don't have separate cadres for intelligence wings, which are generally drawn from the regular police force. States like Gujarat have demanded the establishment of an all India intelligence service, which is yet to be given serious thought by the Centre. As Ajai Sahni, director, Institute for Conflict Management, says: "We don't have an effective intelligence gathering network. There is no way we can have a first-class counter-terrorist set-up with a third-class security system."

Few states have an effective counter-intelligence network to monitor the activities of pro-Islamic militants. Besides the Delhi Police, only the Mumbai Police are known to rely on anti-terrorist squads to keep tabs on suspects and take them in for occasional questioning. The existing intelligence gathering mechanism is largely



deployed to pool information of interest and relevance to those in power in the state. Perhaps the only serious intelligence work they do is in piecing together the activities of Maoists, which, in states like Andhra Pradesh, is the job of an exclusive intelligence branch devoted to Left-wing extremism.

The state intelligence wings of the police are reckoned as the weakest link in the information gathering chain, which is so critical in tracking and detecting the rapidly mutating terror modules across the country. "Terror groups are outsmarting the intelligence set-up in both tactics and technology," says Shashi Kant, additional DGP, Punjab Police. Terrorists have no trouble acquiring SIM cards despite repeated reminders to cellular service providers to develop foolproof identity checks. A bunch of SIM cards procured by terrorists from Kolkata was used in the blasts in Varanasi and Hyderabad.

Security officials point out that co-ordination between the Central agencies still isn't effective. Since the Ministry of Home Affairs created a Multi